Personality

The four big approaches to personality, the Big Five, how much is inherited, how it's measured — and what actually predicts who will perform well in a job.

Isagi · November 2026 · Spine: Ciccarelli & White, *Psychology* (4th ed.), Ch. 13 — rewritten, updated and applied

Companies spend heavily on personality: psychometric tests in hiring, type workshops at offsites, coloured-letter labels on desk name plates. Some of it rests on solid science and some on tests that don't survive scrutiny. This part covers the four classic approaches to personality, the model researchers actually use (the Big Five), what is inherited, how personality is measured — and ends with the question managers care about most: what predicts job performance, and how much.

Personality is a person's characteristic, relatively stable patterns of thinking, feeling and behaving. Four approaches try to explain it.

1 The psychodynamic approach

Sigmund Freud described a mind largely driven by the **unconscious** — wishes, fears and memories outside awareness. He split personality into three parts:

- The **id** — inborn drives seeking immediate gratification (the "pleasure principle").
- The **superego** — the internalised rules of parents and society; the conscience.
- The **ego** — the rational part that negotiates between the two and reality.

When the conflict produces anxiety, the ego uses **defence mechanisms**, which are the part of Freud most useful today because they describe everyday behaviour well:

Defence	What it is	At work
Denial	Refusing to accept reality	"The new competitor won't affect our dealers."
Rationalisation	A plausible excuse for an unacceptable motive	"I didn't want that promotion anyway."
Projection	Attributing your own feelings to others	A manager who resents the boss says the team resents him.
Displacement	Redirecting feelings to a safer target	Shouted at by the RSM, a rep snaps at the distributor's staff.
Sublimation	Channelling impulses into acceptable activity	Aggression into competitive sport.

Freud's theory of psychosexual stages has little scientific support, and much of his theory is hard to test. His followers — the **neo-Freudians** — moved away from sexual drives. Carl Jung added a **collective unconscious** and introduced the ideas of **introversion** and **extraversion**, which survive in modern personality science and, less reliably, in the MBTI (section 6). Alfred Adler emphasised striving to overcome feelings of inferiority, and birth order. Karen Horney stressed social and cultural forces and anxiety in relationships.

2 The behavioural and social-cognitive approach

Behaviourists saw personality as a set of learned responses (Part 4). Albert Bandura's **social-cognitive** view added thought: personality emerges from **reciprocal determinism**, a constant three-way interaction between a person's thinking, their behaviour and the environment. A confident rep seeks out tough accounts, wins some, and becomes more confident. Two concepts from this approach are among the most useful in management:

- **Self-efficacy** — belief in your ability to succeed at a specific task. It predicts effort and persistence and can be built, mainly through small successes, watching similar people succeed, and credible encouragement.

- **Locus of control** (Julian Rotter) — whether you believe outcomes are controlled by your actions (**internal**) or by luck and others (**external**). An internal locus is associated with more effort and better job outcomes.

3 The humanistic approach

Carl Rogers focused on the **self-concept** — how people see themselves. Distress arises when the **real self** (who you are) and the **ideal self** (who you think you should be) are far apart. Growth needs **unconditional positive regard**: acceptance of the person, separate from approval of every action. Rogers's influence is strongest in counselling (Part 12) and in coaching: feedback that criticises a specific behaviour while making clear the person is valued is more likely to be heard than feedback that seems to judge who they are.

4 The trait approach and the Big Five

Trait theorists describe personality as a set of stable dimensions on which people vary. Gordon Allport found thousands of trait words in the dictionary; Raymond Cattell used statistics to boil them down to 16 factors. Later research converged on five broad dimensions that appear across languages and cultures — the **Big Five**, or **OCEAN**:

Trait	High scorers tend to be	At work
Openness to experience	Curious, imaginative, open to new ideas	Adapts to change; useful in creative and strategic roles.
Conscientiousness	Organised, dependable, hard-working	The most consistent Big Five predictor of performance across nearly all jobs.
Extraversion	Sociable, energetic, assertive	Helps somewhat in sales and management roles.
Agreeableness	Cooperative, trusting, kind	Helps in teamwork and service; very high scores may struggle in tough negotiation.
Neuroticism (low: emotional stability)	Anxious, moody, easily stressed	High neuroticism predicts more stress and burnout.

The Big Five are dimensions, not types: most people score somewhere in the middle of each. They are moderately stable across adulthood, and change in predictable ways with age — people tend to become more conscientious and agreeable and less neurotic as they mature. Some researchers add a sixth factor, **honesty–humility** (the HEXACO model), which is particularly relevant to integrity at work.

A long-running debate, the **person–situation debate**, asked whether traits really predict behaviour, since people act differently across situations. The resolution: a trait predicts a single action poorly but predicts a person's average behaviour across many situations well. Situations matter too: a strong situation, such as a clear rule, reduces differences between people.

5 Biology and personality

Twin and adoption studies, including the long-running Minnesota study of twins raised apart, find that roughly 40–50% of the variation in Big Five traits is linked to genetic differences. A surprising finding: the environment siblings share — same home, same parents — explains little of their personality differences. Most of the environmental influence is **non-shared**: different friends, experiences, roles and chance events. Temperament in infancy (Part 7) is an early, partly inherited root.

6 Measuring personality

- **Interviews** — **unstructured** interviews (a free-flowing conversation) are weak and prone to bias. **Structured** interviews, where every candidate gets the same job-related questions scored on a set rubric, are among the best predictors of performance (section 7).
- **Projective tests** — the person interprets an ambiguous image: the **Rorschach** inkblots, or the **Thematic Apperception Test (TAT)**, which asks for stories about pictures. The idea is that people project their unconscious onto the image. Reliability and validity are weak for most uses.
- **Personality inventories** — standardised questionnaires. The **MMPI** is used clinically and has built-in scales to detect lying or random

answering. The **NEO-PI** and similar instruments measure the Big Five and are the tools used in research.

The Barnum effect

In 1949 psychologist Bertram Forer gave his students a "personalised" personality profile and asked them to rate its accuracy. They rated it about 4.3 out of 5. Everyone had received the same text, assembled from horoscopes: "You have a great need for other people to like and admire you… At times you are extroverted, affable, sociable, while at other times you are introverted, wary, reserved." The **Barnum effect** is our tendency to accept vague, flattering descriptions as uniquely accurate. It explains why people find almost any personality report convincing, which is why "it felt so accurate" is not evidence that a test works.

The MBTI problem

The **Myers–Briggs Type Indicator**, built in the 1940s on Jung's ideas, sorts people into 16 types from four either/or choices (for example, introvert or extravert). It is enormously popular in companies. Its problems are well documented. Most traits are normally distributed, so most people are near the middle — and a forced either/or split puts people who barely differ into opposite types. Many people get a different type when they retake it after a few weeks. And type has little demonstrated power to predict job performance.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1 · WHY TYPE TESTS FLIP

Suppose a person sits near the middle on several MBTI scales, so on retest each of the four letters has an 80% chance of coming out the same (illustrative).

$$P(\text{all four letters the same}) = 0.8 \times 0.8 \times 0.8 \times 0.8 = 0.8^4 \approx 0.41$$

Even with each letter fairly stable, there's only about a 41% chance of getting the same four-letter type. That is a mechanical result of cutting continuous traits into categories. The Big Five avoids it by reporting scores, not types. If your company uses MBTI for team-building conversations, fine; for hiring, promotion or team assignment, it is the wrong tool.

7 What predicts job performance

Validity in hiring is measured as the correlation (r, Part 0) between a selection method's scores and later job performance. In 1998 Frank Schmidt and John Hunter published an influential summary that put general mental ability (Part 6) near the top. A 2022 re-analysis by Paul Sackett and colleagues corrected a statistical over-adjustment in that work and revised many estimates downward. Approximate values from the 2022 analysis:

Method	Approximate validity (r)
Structured interview	~0.42
Work-sample test	~0.33
General mental ability test	~0.31
Conscientiousness	~0.19
Unstructured interview	~0.19

Figures are rounded and vary across jobs; combining methods predicts better than any single one.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2 · WHAT R ACTUALLY BUYS YOU

The share of performance differences a predictor accounts for is roughly r^2:

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Structured interview:   0.42² ≈ 0.18  → about 18%
Conscientiousness:      0.19² ≈ 0.04  → about 4%
Unstructured interview: 0.19² ≈ 0.04  → about 4%
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Two lessons. First, even the best single method leaves most of the variation in performance unexplained, so humility in hiring is warranted. Second, a structured interview accounts for roughly four times as much variance as an unstructured chat that takes the same hour. Moving from "tell me about yourself" to a fixed set of job-related questions with a scoring rubric is the cheapest improvement most hiring processes can make. (r^2 understates practical value somewhat — even modest correlations improve the average quality of hires noticeably — but the comparison between methods holds.)

8 Held up?

Claim	Verdict	Why
Personality has five broad dimensions	**Robust**	Replicated across languages and cultures; a sixth (honesty–humility) is well supported too.
MBTI type predicts job fit	**No**	Types are unstable on retest and show little predictive validity.
Birth order shapes personality	**No**	Large studies of tens of thousands of people find no meaningful effect on Big Five traits.
Inkblot tests reveal hidden personality	**Weak**	Poor reliability and validity for most uses.
Handwriting analysis predicts performance	**No**	Studies find no validity once the content of the writing is controlled.
Conscientiousness predicts performance	**Yes, modestly**	Consistent across jobs, though smaller than once thought.

Summary

- **Personality** is a stable pattern of thinking, feeling and behaving, studied through four approaches.
- **Psychodynamic**: id, ego, superego and the unconscious. Most of Freud is untestable, but **defence mechanisms** describe everyday behaviour well. Jung's introversion–extraversion survives.
- **Social-cognitive**: reciprocal determinism; **self-efficacy** and **internal locus of control** predict effort and can be built.
- **Humanistic**: Rogers's self-concept and unconditional positive regard — criticise behaviour, value the person.
- **Trait**: the **Big Five** (openness, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness, neuroticism) are dimensions, moderately stable, and conscientiousness is the most consistent work predictor.
- About 40–50% of trait variation is linked to genes; shared family environment explains little.
- Structured interviews and inventories work; projective tests are weak. The **Barnum effect** makes any vague profile feel accurate. **MBTI** types are unstable — even 80% stability per letter gives only about a 41% chance of the same type.
- Best predictors of job performance (2022): structured interviews (~0.42), work samples (~0.33), general mental ability (~0.31). Unstructured interviews and conscientiousness are about 0.19.

Practice problems

P1. Name the defence mechanism: (a) after losing a key dealer, a rep says "he was a bad payer anyway"; (b) a manager who is cutting corners accuses his team of cutting corners; (c) a rep insists the market slowdown "won't reach our district".

P2. A new rep has low self-efficacy about institutional sales. Using Bandura, list three ways to build it.

P3. Which Big Five trait would you most want to measure for a collections-heavy territory role, and why? Which might matter for a key-account role that requires tough negotiation?

P4. If each MBTI letter has a 70% chance of staying the same on retest, what's the chance of the same four-letter type?

P5. Your company hires reps through one unstructured 30-minute interview. Using the validity table, redesign the process within the same total time per candidate.

P6. A vendor sells a personality report and says "95% of candidates say it describes them perfectly". Why is that not evidence the test works? What evidence would you ask for?

Glossary

Personality

Characteristic, stable patterns of thinking, feeling and behaving.

Id / ego / superego

Freud's drives / rational mediator / conscience.

Defence mechanism

An unconscious way of reducing anxiety by distorting reality.

Reciprocal determinism

Thinking, behaviour and environment influencing each other.

Self-efficacy

Belief in your ability to succeed at a specific task.

Locus of control

Belief that outcomes depend on yourself (internal) or outside forces (external).

Unconditional positive regard

Accepting a person regardless of specific behaviour.

Trait

A stable dimension on which people differ.

Big Five (OCEAN)

Openness, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness, neuroticism.

Non-shared environment

Experiences that differ between siblings.

Projective test

A test asking people to interpret ambiguous stimuli.

Personality inventory

A standardised questionnaire measuring traits.

Barnum effect

Accepting vague, general descriptions as personally accurate.

Structured interview

Same job-related questions for every candidate, scored on a rubric.

Validity coefficient
The correlation between a selection method and job performance.

Answer key

P1. (a) rationalisation; (b) projection; (c) denial.

P2. Small early wins (a first institutional call with an easy, warm prospect); modelling (joint visits watching a peer like him succeed); credible, specific encouragement and feedback.

P3. Collections: conscientiousness — persistence, follow-up, organisation. Key accounts: lower extreme agreeableness can help in tough negotiation, alongside conscientiousness and emotional stability.

P4. $0.7^4 \approx$ **0.24** — about a one-in-four chance.

P5. For example: a 20-minute structured interview with five fixed job-related questions scored on a rubric by two interviewers, plus a 10-minute work sample — handling a role-played dealer objection — scored on a checklist.

P6. The Barnum effect: people rate vague, flattering profiles as accurate regardless of the test. Ask for test–retest reliability, and validity data showing that scores predict job performance in a role like ours, ideally from independent studies.

Sources: chapter structure follows Ciccarelli & White, *Psychology*, 4th ed. (Pearson), Ch. 13; text and figures are original. Big Five: McCrae & Costa; HEXACO: Ashton & Lee. Forer, 1949. MBTI reliability: Pittenger, 1993, and later reviews. Birth order: Rohrer, Egloff & Schmukle, *PNAS*, 2015. Selection validity: Schmidt & Hunter, *Psychological Bulletin*, 1998; Sackett et al., *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 2022. Worked example 1 uses illustrative probabilities.